

FIFA World Cup Educational Game

Lesson Content Specification

Lesson 1 - Qualifications

Lesson Objective	Lesson Description
Help users understand how teams qualify for the FIFA World Cup through each regional confederation.	This lesson explains the qualification process for the 2026 World Cup, which expanded from 32 to 48 nations. It covers how each of the six confederations runs its qualifiers, how host nations receive automatic spots, and how the inter-confederation playoff decides the final places.

Learning Content

Section 1: Overview

- Hosted in North America (USA, Canada, Mexico)
- Qualification began in September 2023
- Expanded from 32 to 48 nations

Section 2: Confederation Qualifying

AFC (Asia) - 8 direct spots: Five rounds. The weakest 20 teams play knockout matches first, then join stronger teams in group stages, narrowing to 3 groups of 6. Top 2 from each group qualify (8 teams). A further round gives Iraq the inter-confederation playoff spot. So a total of 8 teams qualify directly for the World Cup. An additional one or two teams could potentially qualify through the Inter-confederation playoff tournament, bringing the total to 9 or 10 teams.

UEFA (Europe) - 16 direct spots: The tournament consists of 12 groups. Each group winner qualifies directly. Second-place teams along with the four best ranked UEFA Nations League winners enter a mini knockout playoff for the final 4 spots. The Nations League offers a “second chance” to qualify for the World Cup.

CAF (Africa) - 9 direct spots: Teams were drawn into 9 groups of 6 teams. The winner of each group directly qualifies. Runner-ups of the 4 best groups advance to the tournament playoffs. Second-place teams play a mini tournament, and the winner (Democratic Republic of the Congo (DR CONGO)) advances to the Inter-confederation playoff. 9 teams secure direct qualification and a 10th spot is potentially secured through the Inter-confederation playoff.

CONMEBOL (South America) - 6 direct spots: Only 10 member countries, so all teams play in a single league table. Each team played each other team twice in a home-and-away round robin format. Top 6 qualify; 7th place (Bolivia) went to the inter-confederation playoff. 6 teams qualify directly, and a 7th team can qualify through the inter-confederation playoff.

CONCACAF (North/Central America & Caribbean) - 6 spots: USA, Mexico, and Canada get automatic host spots. 3 additional direct slots come from group stage winners; 2 runners-up (Jamaica, Suriname) go to the Inter-confederation playoff. In other words, six teams directly qualify, and possibly 2 more teams if they win the Inter-confederation playoff.

Normally gets 6 World Cup spots, but this time 3 were taken by the hosts (USA, Mexico, Canada), leaving only 3 direct spots + 2 playoff spots for the other 32 countries in the region to fight over. In the first round, the 4 weakest teams (ranked #29-32 on the FIFA rankings) played each other in two-legged (home and away) knockout matches. 2 winners advanced to the second round. In the second round, 2 winners from first round joined the 28 better-ranked teams to make 30 total. The teams were split into 6 groups of 5. Each team played others only once. Top 2 from each group advanced to the third round (12 teams left standing). In the third round, 12 teams were split into 3 groups of 4, playing each team twice, home and away. The 3 group winners directly qualified. 2 best runners-up (Jamaica and Suriname) went to the inter-confederation playoff (both lost there).

OFC (Oceania) - 1 direct spot: Oceania's first-ever guaranteed spot. Group stage then knockout. 11 teams played in the OFC qualification tournament. In the first round, the four lowest ranked teams in the FIFA Men's World Rankings played a 3-match knockout round. Winner advances to the second round. In the second round, the winner from the first round joined the 7 highest ranked teams in two 4-team groups. Top 2 teams from each group advanced to the third round. In the third round, the 4 teams that are left play a 3-match knockout round. Winner qualifies directly for the World Cup. Runner-up advances to the Inter-confederation playoff. New Zealand qualified directly, with second place (New Caledonia) going to the playoff.

Section 3: Inter-confederation Playoff

Six teams played in Mexico in March 2026 for 2 final spots. The 2 highest-ranked teams received byes to the finals while the other 4 played knockout matches. DR Congo and Iraq won the final 2 World Cup spots.

Quiz Questions

Question	Options	Correct Answer
A CONMEBOL team finishes 7 th in the final league table. What happens to them?	- They're eliminated - They qualify directly - They go to the inter-confederation playoff - They enter a European playoff	They go to the inter-confederation playoff
Why does CONCACAF have only 3 direct qualifying slots	- Two slots are reserved for Caribbean nations	Three host nations received automatic spots, using up

available despite getting 5 total spots?	- Three host nations received automatic spots, using up the rest - FIFA capped direct slots at 3 per region - Two slots went to OFC instead	the rest
Which statement about the inter-confederation playoff is correct?	- All 6 teams played a single knockout round - The two highest ranked teams got byes to the finals. - Only CONCACAF teams were eligible - It was held in San Francisco	The two highest ranked teams got byes to the finals.
Which confederation got a guaranteed spot for the first time in 2026?	- Africa (CAF) - Asia (AFC) - Oceania (OFC) - South America (CONMEBOL)	Oceania (OFC)

Additional questions:

Q: UEFA group winners qualify automatically. How are the remaining 4 European spots decided?

- By FIFA ranking
- **A knockout playoff between second place teams**
- A second group stage
- Random draw

Lesson 2 - Countries Represented

Lesson Objective	Lesson Description
Help users understand which countries are competing in the 2026 World Cup.	This lesson covers the 48 participating nations by confederation, highlighting stronger teams, first-timers, and new records such as record Arab representation and Italy's absence.

Learning Content

Section 1: Europe (16 teams)

Europe has won more World Cups than all other continents combined and fields the traditional favorites. Spain, France, Germany, England, and Portugal are leading contenders. Italy, a 4-time winner, failed to qualify for the third straight tournament.

Qualified: Spain, France, England, Germany, Portugal, Netherlands, Belgium, Croatia, Switzerland, Austria, Norway, Scotland, Sweden, Türkiye, Bosnia & Herzegovina, Czechia.

Section 2: South America (6 teams)

Although CONMEBOL has only 10 members, its teams are strong contenders. Argentina are defending champions (won the 2022 final). Brazil has won the most World Cups and is the only country to qualify for every tournament since 1930. Brazil has won the World Cup in 1958, 1962, 1970, 1994, and 2002. Uruguay won the first World Cup in 1930.

Qualified: Argentina, Brazil, Colombia, Uruguay, Ecuador, Paraguay.

Section 3: Africa (10 teams)

Africa's biggest ever World Cup presence, up from 5 spots in 2022. DR Congo returns to the World Cup after a 52-year absence. This is the record for the longest gap between World Cup appearances.

Qualified: Morocco, Senegal, Ivory Coast, Egypt, Algeria, Ghana, South Africa, Tunisia, Cape Verde (debut), DR Congo (first since 1974).

Cape Verde secured their debut at the World Cup 2026 after beating Eswatini 3-0.

Section 4: Asia (9 teams)

Several nations are debuting or returning after long absences. A record 8 Arab nations qualified across Asia and Africa combined. They are Algeria, Egypt, Iraq, Jordan, Morocco, Qatar, Saudi Arabia, and Tunisia.

Qualified: Japan, South Korea, Australia, Iran, Saudi Arabia, Qatar, Jordan (debut), Uzbekistan (debut), Iraq (first since 1986).

Section 5: North/Central America & Caribbean (6 teams)

The host region: USA, Canada, and Mexico received automatic spots, leaving 3 additional qualifying places. The Caribbean is represented for the first time in decades.

Qualified: USA, Mexico, Canada, Curaçao (smallest country ever to qualify), Haiti (first since 1974), Panama.

Curacao's population is 156,000. They are the smallest country ever to qualify for the World Cup. They secured their debut spot with 7 wins and 3 draws during the qualification process. They finished first in Group B

Section 6: Oceania (1 team)

The smallest confederation received its first guaranteed spot. Qualified: New Zealand. New Zealand's last appearance was in 2010. They went undefeated in the group stage but still didn't advance to the knockout stage.

Quiz Questions

Question	Options	Correct Answer
Which country has qualified for every World Cup since 1930?	- Germany - Argentina - Brazil - Italy	Brazil
Four countries are making their first World Cup appearance in 2026. Which of these is one of them?	- Cape Verde - Haiti - DR Congo - Iraq	Cape Verde
A 4-time World Cup winner failed to qualify for the third tournament in a row. Who?	- England - Germany - France - Italy	Italy
How many Arab nations qualified for 2026, a record?	- 4 - 6 - 8 - 10	8

Additional questions:

Q: Which of these countries did not qualify for the 2026 World Cup?

- Uzbekistan
- Curacao
- **Lebanon**
- Cape Verde